

Old-Home Rental Toolkit

Old-Home Rental Toolkit — Product & Build Plan

Owner: Brian Quaresma **Status:** Pre-build planning **Last updated:** September 15, 2026

1. Vision

A landlord toolkit built specifically for **one-of-a-kind older homes in desirable, walkable urban neighborhoods** — not apartments, not tract housing. Covers the full lifecycle: list → find tenant → screen → lease → collect rent → manage requests. Free-to-landlord core, monetized on the applicant side.

Why this niche wins: Generic tools (TurboTenant, Avail, RentRedi, Buildium) are built around filterable specs — bed/bath/sqft/amenities grids — which undersell a character property and mishandle its actual compliance profile. No incumbent owns “old house rental.” The whitespace is real, not just positioning.

2. Target Customer

Attribute	Definition
Who	Self-managing landlord, 1-10 doors, owns pre-1978 character properties (rowhouses, Victorians, converted multi-units)
Where	Walkable, historic-adjacent urban neighborhoods (e.g., Lawrenceville/Bloomfield Pittsburgh, Baltimore rowhouse neighborhoods, similar Rust Belt/legacy-city markets)
Not who	Large PM portfolios, new-construction multifamily, suburban tract-home landlords
Brian’s edge	Owns a pre-1978 Pittsburgh property, actively evaluating Baltimore/Cleveland — built-in first beta property and realistic user-interview access before needing outside validation

3. Competitive Landscape

Player	Model	Gap for this niche
TurboTenant / Avail / RentRedi /	Free-to-landlord, applicant-paid	Generic listing schema, no

Innago	screening	character/story field, no lead-paint-specific workflow
Buildium / AppFolio	Full PM suites	Built for portfolios, not solo landlords; overkill and expensive
Zillow Rental Manager	Free basic listings, ~34M monthly visitors	Largest free audience — use as a channel, not a competitor
Circa Old Houses (and similar)	Historic home marketplace	Sale only, not rental — no direct competitor on the rental side
Syndication tools (Reallyo, Landlord Studio, RentecDirect)	Post once, push to multiple portals	Useful as a distribution layer, not a product differentiator

Market note: Zillow became the exclusive listing provider for larger multifamily buildings (25+ units) across Redfin, Rent.com, and ApartmentGuide.com in early 2025 — under FTC/state antitrust scrutiny. Irrelevant to your persona (small/solo landlords aren't affected), but confirms the strategic point: **own your listing data and your own site as the source of truth**, treat portals as distribution.

4. Product Phases

Phase 0 — Validate (1-2 weeks)

- Confirm the persona and pain-point priority (finding/screening tenants) against 5-10 real conversations, ideally within Brian's own Pittsburgh/Baltimore/Cleveland network.
- Confirm the "free listing everywhere" promise is honest: Zillow basic tier is free; most others are not. Don't oversell.

Phase 1 — MVP: Find & Screen

Core loop: list → lead → application → screen → decide.

Feature	Notes
Property/unit setup	Address, rent, photos, availability, lease terms
Character-forward listing builder	Narrative/story block as first-class field; flexible layout schema for non-standard rooms (converted attic, carriage house unit, non-conforming bedroom)
Public listing page	Shareable URL — this is the durable asset, independent of any portal
Zillow Rental Manager feed integration	Primary free distribution channel
Manual-export formatting for Craigslist / Facebook Marketplace	Both restrict automated posting by individual landlords — build a "copy-formatted listing" button rather than fighting ToS
Lead inbox	All inquiries in one place, regardless of source
Prescreening questionnaire	Income, move-in date, pets, credit range — filters before paid screening

Digital rental application	Customizable fields, e-signature on consent
Lead-based paint disclosure workflow	Mandatory, non-skippable step for any pre-1978 property — auto-triggered by build year field
Tenant screening (TransUnion SmartMove)	API + webhook (screening.completed) integration; applicant pushes own report; applicant-pays option keeps core product free
Decision workflow	Score against stated criteria; approve/deny/waitlist; auto-generate adverse-action notices

Phase 2 — Payments & Communication

- Rent collection via Stripe Connect (or Plaid + Dwolla for ACH-only)
- Maintenance request intake + status tracking, tied to property record
- Tenant-landlord messaging thread, tied to lease

Phase 3 — Retention & Expansion

- Lease renewal workflows, state-compliant rent-increase notice timing
- Basic bookkeeping/tax export per property
- Multi-property portfolio view

Phase 4 — Scale

- Local Realtor-fed rental MLS syndication (relevant to character homes specifically)
- Auto-generated social/share cards per listing (Instagram/Pinterest-style presentation — character-home renters over-index on aesthetic discovery channels vs. generic portal search)
- Historic-district renovation/permitting disclosure checklist (market-dependent, e.g., Pittsburgh, Baltimore review boards)

5. Compliance Requirements

This is a **core product feature for this niche**, not boilerplate — because the target property set is disproportionately pre-1978.

Federal baseline (Title X / Lead-Based Paint Disclosure Rule)

- Required for all pre-1978 rental housing before lease signing or renewal
- Landlord must: disclose known lead-based paint/hazards, provide the EPA pamphlet (“Protect Your Family from Lead in Your Home”), retain signed disclosure for 3+ years
- **Penalty exposure: up to ~\$19,500 per violation**, plus personal liability (treble damages) if a tenant or child is harmed
- Exempt: 0-bedroom housing (studios), leases of 100 days or fewer

State add-ons (build as jurisdiction-aware logic keyed to city/state + build year)

State	Additional requirement
Massachusetts	Lead inspection required before renting to families

	with children under 6; must delead or apply interim controls if hazards found
New York (NYC)	Local Law 1: annual visual inspection for peeling paint in pre-1960 buildings where children under 6 reside
Maryland	Lead-safe registration + periodic inspection required for pre-1978 rentals
Rhode Island	Lead-safe certification with mandatory inspections

Other standing compliance items (not niche-specific, still required)

- **FCRA** — permissible-purpose and adverse-action rules apply regardless of screening vendor; liability stays with the landlord
- **Fair Housing Act** — application forms and any auto-scoring logic must not create disparate impact on protected classes; legal review before launch, not after
- **Screening data limits vary by state** — e.g., SmartMove only returns criminal records in 30 states

6. Tech Architecture

Layer	Choice	Rationale
Frontend/backend	Next.js (App Router)	Single codebase for marketing site + app, fast solo iteration
Database	Postgres (Supabase or Neon)	Relational model fits leases/applications/payments
Auth	Multi-tenant from day one	Landlord, applicant/tenant, future team-member roles
Payments	Stripe Connect	Each landlord = connected account; Stripe absorbs most PCI/compliance burden
Screening	TransUnion SmartMove API	Established, FCRA-compliant, applicant-pays option available
Listing distribution	Zillow feed integration first	Manual-export for Craigslist/Facebook until volume justifies syndication partnership
File/photo storage	Cloudflare R2 (S3-compatible)	Lower cost at this scale
Background jobs	Inngest or BullMQ	Needed for screening webhooks, rent reminders, renewal triggers

7. Monetization

Model	Mechanics	Recommendation
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Applicant-paid screening	Landlord free, applicant pays SmartMove fee	Start here — matches category norm, lowest adoption friction
Freemium SaaS	Free for 1 unit, paid tiers by unit count	Add once portfolio-management features (Phase 3) exist
Payment processing fee	Small % or flat fee on rent collection	Defer to Phase 2
Listing boost fee	Pass-through cost for premium portal placement (e.g., Apartments.com)	Optional add-on, doesn't compromise free core promise

8. Go-to-Market

- **Seed customer:** Brian's own Pittsburgh property — first real listing, first real compliance test, first real screening cycle.
- **Early network:** Landlords in Pittsburgh/Baltimore/Cleveland rowhouse and historic-district circles — direct overlap with Brian's own property search activity.
- **Channel-market fit:** Neighborhood Facebook groups, Nextdoor, local Realtor-fed rental feeds — these outperform generic portal search for character-home renters and are underused by incumbents.
- **Positioning line to test:** "Built for landlords of homes that don't fit a template" — differentiate explicitly against the bed/bath/sqft grid model.

9. Risks & Open Questions

Risk	Mitigation
"Free everywhere" promise overreach	Be explicit: free where Zillow's basic tier applies; manual-assist elsewhere; paid boost optional
FCRA/Fair Housing liability	Legal review of application forms and scoring logic before first real applicant
Lead disclosure skipped by landlord users	Make it a hard gate in the lease flow, not an optional checkbox
Niche too small to sustain a business	Validate in Phase 0 before scaling past Pittsburgh/Baltimore/Cleveland-type markets
Solo build bandwidth vs. scope	Hold the line on MVP feature list — Phase 2/3 items are explicitly deferred, not "if time allows"

10. Immediate Next Steps

1. Lock Phase 1 scope (table in Section 4) — no additions before it ships.
2. Confirm SmartMove API access and Zillow Rental Manager feed documentation — both integrations gate architecture decisions.

3. Get informal Fair Housing / FCRA review of application and scoring logic.
4. Draft the jurisdiction-aware lead-disclosure compliance checklist (federal + MA/NY/MD/RI variants above) as a standalone reference doc.
5. Stand up Next.js + Postgres skeleton with landlord auth and property CRUD, including the character-forward listing schema.